The Plains

Stretching from the Mississippi River to the Rocky Mountains from the Gulf of Mexico to modern day Canada, the Plains region was home to smaller cultures who spoke a variety of languages including Uto-Aztecan, Algonquian and Siouan. These people enjoyed a rather stable existence by farming and hunting. When the settlers introduced the use of horses in the 1700s, the Native Americans began a nomadic lifestyle. They would forage and find food by travelling long distances. Some of the well-known groups such as the Comanche, Blackfeet and the Crow chased buffalos over the plains and lived within their iconic teepees. The teepees were made from the skin of bison and were easily taken down for travel. These tribes were famous for their richly decorated war hats that were made from beautiful feathers.

A number of things brought by the European settlers shaped the future for the Plains' natives. The Europeans traded kettles, knives and guns until the Native Americans began to rely upon them. The settlers brought death in the form of various diseases the natives had never experienced before. Their immune system could not combat small pox and many natives died as a result. The latter part of the 19th century saw the killing of buffalo herds by the settlers who hunted them for sport. Since the Native Americans could not earn a living and the Europeans controlled the lands, the Plains' people had no choice but to move to the reservations created for them by the government.